that point with a verbal volley on "the attitude of people from the South". The said community, he said, "operated dance bars and ladies bars in Maharashtra" and "ruined its culture and youth". His pique apparently originates with the canteen contractor, said to be a Shetty from Karnataka. The recourse to nativist vocabulary was a transparent attempt to deflect focus from his own misdemeanour, and its effect is minimised by the fact that the speaker has earned some renown as an equal opportunity offender.

Days earlier, he had made disparaging remarks about Chhatrapati Sambhaji, for which he had to apologise. In May, Gaikwad lashed out at the Maharashtra police, calling it "the most inefficient police department in India and the world", with a compulsive penchant for "*hafta* (extortion)" to boot. That had made even CM Devendra Fadnavis see red. Last September, Gaikwad offered Rs 11 lakh to anyone who would "chop off the tongue" of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. He also claimed to have killed a tiger and worn its tooth as a pendant. When AIMIM MP Imtiaz Jaleel criticised Gaikwad for his canteen exploits, he threatened to assault Jaleel too.

Shinde is said to have upbraided Gaikwad. After three days of Opposition protests, Fadnavis stepped in and a suo moto non-cognisable case was filed by the Marine Drive police. But the man remains defiant for now. ■

Takeaways

- **Shinde Sena MLA Sanjay Gaikwad slaps a canteen staffer; video goes viral**
- **Later, he waxes indignant on "South Indians", claiming they're ruining Maharashtra**

▶ JHARKHAND

LICENCE TO LOOT

A liquor scam exposes a network of forged guarantees, policy manipulation and bureaucratic connivance

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

On June 17, when the Jharkhand Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) arrested former IAS officer Amit Prakash, he joined the ignominious ranks of two others who were arrested the previous month: serving IAS officer Vinay Kumar Choubey and former excise commissioner Gajendra Singh. All are now cooling their heels in judicial custody. So, what's brewing? A full-blown excise scam—vatfuls of it, in fact. And net losses are pegged at Rs 38 crore.

Prakash, who retired last December after serving as excise commissioner and managing director of the Jharkhand State Beverage Corporation Ltd (JSBCL), stands accused of authorising payments totalling approximately Rs 11 crore to two liquor wholesalers, despite directives to withhold those funds. But the ramifications extend far beyond Prakash.

It all began to unfold through murmurings of a similar scam in neighbouring Chhattisgarh in 2024. In Jharkhand, it first came to light in May, when the ACB apprehended Choubey—once a key aide to chief minister Hemant Soren—on charges of causing massive financial losses to the exchequer. Since then, it has escalated into what seems a multi-layered case of systemic corruption.

At its core lies a nexus of bureaucrats, businessmen and excise officials who allegedly manipulated policies and institutional blind spots to run an illegal liquor syndicate spanning state borders. With 10 arrests so far, including those of private operators and a hologram supplier, and amid calls for a CBI inquiry by the Opposition BJP, the racket marks a pivotal moment for public accountability.

Irregularities surround the 2022-23 excise policy—specifically, the appointment of placement agencies in contravention of norms. Allegations include rigged tenders, fake bank guarantees, sale of unaccounted domestic and foreign liquor via duplicate holograms and the generation of illicit commissions.

DUBIOUS OPERATORS

Two agencies are central to the probe: Vision Hospitality Services & Consultants Pvt. Ltd and Marshan Innovative Security Services Pvt. Ltd. Empanelled by the excise department in June 2023, they were tasked with



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BEHIND BARS Amit Prakash and Vinay Choubey (top) in custody